



Nurse-led Swallow Screening

To be used for all stroke patients and for patients where bulbar problems are suspected

PATIENT ASSESSMENT

STAGE 1

Do any of the following apply to the patient?

- Poor GCS
- NP airway
- Intermittently drowsy

YES

Too early for
swallow assessment
Keep NBM

YES

STAGE 2

Does the patient show signs
bulbar neurological symptoms?

- Evidence of aspiration of secretions?
- Persistent wet, gurgly or weak cough
- Coughing when swallowing secretions

NO

STAGE 3

Do any of the following apply?

- Lengthy ETT intubation (especially if patient has good tube tolerance)
- Tracheostomy

YES

**Patient requires
SALT Assessment
Keep NBM and
refer to SALT**

Nurse-in-Charge must check if
patient in any of following categories

- Anterior cervical discectomy
- Transoral or CPA surgery
- Acoustic neuroma

YES

STAGE 6

Is there evidence of the following?

- No attempt to swallow
- Coughing / choking
- Wet 'gurgly' voice
- Breathlessness
- Drooling of food or fluids
- No laryngeal elevation
- Fatigue when swallowing
- Complaint of food sticking in throat

NO

STAGE 7

If there are no adverse signs

- Document swallow screen
- Commence soft diet (NOT PUREE) with normal fluids
- Monitor swallowing for 1st meal – does patient swallow without difficulty?
- If all OK proceed to normal fluids and normal diet
- Continue to check for adverse signs

STAGE 4

Patient is suitable for
NURSE-LED ASSESSMENT

STAGE 5

STEP 1

Ensure patient is fully alert and sat as upright as possible (care post op acoustics who might be nauseous and patients with positioning limitations)

STEP 2

Are all of the following present

- Strong cough ✓
- Ability to manage secretions ✓
- Clear sounding voice ✓

STEP 3

Is the patient able to swallow?

- 3 teaspoons of water
- 5 sips of water from a cup
- 3 teaspoons of yoghurt